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DEAD WRONG



AP PHOTO

In December last year, nine people were crushed inside the Qualis when a truck coming from the opposite direction and on the wrong side of the road rammed into them at the Panvel-Thane junction of Navi Mumbai. The crushed vehicle had to be cut to extricate the bodies. The driver fled the scene before the police arrived. Reckless driving and high fatigue levels of truck drivers have made the Mumbai-Pune Expressway a death trap during certain hours. During the wee hours trucks move in the wrong lanes and run into unsuspecting vehicles. In May last year, 14 people of a marriage party were killed at 4.30 a.m. when they collided with a tanker which had slowed down near Panvel.

TRUCKS MOVING IN THE WRONG DIRECTION ARE A LEADING CAUSE OF ACCIDENTS ON THE MUMBAI-PUNE EXPRESSWAY.



thetic a view... is counterproductive in the long run and against the social interest which needs to be strengthened by a string of deterrence in-built in the sentencing system."

Adding fuel to the fire is a lax and corrupt licensing system that sends a clear message: you can drive a car without knowing traffic rules. In reality, driving licences are like a licence to kill. In many states, notably Uttar Pradesh, Bihar and Madhya Pradesh, there is no need to even go to the licensing authority to get a licence made, thanks to touts. Raids by Delhi's Anti-Corruption Branch have exposed the corruption in the system which allows people to get licences without taking the mandatory driving test. Many so-called driving schools function more as middlemen who get licences without any mandatory checks.

Public transport accounts for a major portion of road deaths, and sleep deprivation and abnormal sleep patterns have emerged as a major prob-

POOR PUBLIC TRANSPORT IS A MAJOR CAUSE OF ACCIDENTS

lem. A recent study by the All India Institute of Medical Sciences (AIIMS) found that 60 per cent of accidents were due to insufficient sleep or abnormal sleeping habits of professional drivers. Truck and long distance bus drivers are the prime culprits. In fact, the major death traps in India, according to statistics, are the Delhi-Jaipur expressway (where Michelle Vadra, the sister-in-law of Priyanka Gandhi, was killed in 2001), the Gurgaon Expressway, the Mumbai-Pune Expressway, the Ahmedabad-Vadodara Expressway in Gujarat, and the Bangalore-Mysore Infrastructure Corridor.

There is also another killer: the lack of speedy medical help and transfer to a hospital. One tragic example is that of 19-year-old hotel management student Rahul Anand who rammed his car into a parked water tanker on the Delhi-